

A NEW ORDER

New states rise at KIWG 2026, **signalling** a change in the country's skating landscape.

Aneesh Dey

aneesh.dey@thehindu.co.in

Of the 14 events at the recently concluded Khelo India Winter Games (KIWG) 2026 in Leh, 13 gold medals were claimed by states which, until recently, scarcely figured in conversations around Indian ice sports. The podium, once imagined as the preserve of cold-climate regions, now reflected a shifting geography — one shaped as much by ambition as by altitude.

Haryana finished atop the medal tally with seven medals, including four golds. The southern states followed, defying climatic logic if not competitive sense: Kerala, Tamil Nadu and Karnataka all returned home with gold medals. In contrast, Ladakh — long regarded as the cradle of India's winter sports ecosystem — managed just two gold medals, thus underscoring the Games' most striking takeaway: ice sports in India are no longer tethered to where it naturally forms.

What unfolded over the course of the Games was not an anomaly but the product of slow, uneven change. States without snow or frozen lakes are investing in talent identification, exposure and grassroots participation, often driven by individual coaches, determined families and a handful of private facilities. The medals were not just rewards for performance but markers of a quiet rebalancing.

According to Amitabh Sharma, president of the Ice Skating Association of India (ISAI), this redistribution of success mirrors a broader surge in participation. "Two or three years ago, the total bandwidth was between 500 and 700 athletes," he says. "Today, we are touching almost 4,000 pan-India."

For a sport once viewed as peripheral, the numbers point to genuine momentum — even if infrastructure, funding and institutional support have struggled to keep pace. That tension is evident beneath the medal tables. Participation may be widening, but growth remains fragile, uneven and constrained by lack

Gliding to glory: An aerial shot of skaters getting ready at Gupuks Pond, the venue for long track speed skating at the Khelo India Winter Games.

Pics: KIWG 2026

